

A

With adjectives

Prefixes, e.g. **un-**, **dis-**, **im-**, can be added to some adjectives to give the opposite meaning.

happy	un happy
possible	im possible
regular	ir regular

honest [tells the truth]	dis honest
correct [right✓]	in correct
legal [allowed by law]	il legal

Dan used all the milk but said he didn't; he's very **dishonest**.

I got eight answers right, but two were **incorrect**.

It's **illegal** in the UK to ride a motorbike without a helmet.

B

un-

Of the prefixes above, **un-** is the most common, and appears in a number of adjectives.

This chair is incredibly **uncomfortable**.

It was **unnecessary** for them to wait for us.

Xerxes – that's a very **unusual** name. [different, not common or ordinary]

I won the game; it was completely **unexpected**. [I didn't think I was going to win]

Marsha's hat is **unbelievable**. [surprising because it is either very good or very bad]

We tried to open the door, but we **were unable to** get in. [could not]

I need to do more exercise; I'm very **unfit**. [not healthy and not in good condition]

Declan played well, and I thought he was **unlucky** to lose.

They're **unlikely** to get here before midday. [They probably won't get here before midday.]

The test was **unfair** because some of the students had more time to do it than others. [If something is *unfair*, it does not treat people equally.]

Language help

Adding a negative prefix does not usually change the pronunciation; the stress stays the same.
She was un'lucky. It's unbe'lievable. (NOT She was 'unlucky. It was 'unbelievable.)

C

With verbs

With some verbs, these prefixes can have particular meanings.

dis- [the opposite of something]	I disagree with the others. [don't agree / have the same opinion] The plane appeared in the sky, then it disappeared behind a cloud.
un- [the opposite of an action]	I couldn't unlock the door this morning. [open the door using a key; <i>opp lock</i>] We had to get undressed in the cold. [take off our clothes; <i>opp get dressed</i>] I unpacked the bags. [took everything out of the bags; <i>opp pack</i>]
over- [too much]	The bank overcharged me. [asked me to pay too much money]
mis- [do something incorrectly]	I misunderstood what he said; I'm afraid my English isn't very good. I misheard her. I thought she said <i>Rita</i> , not <i>Brita</i> .
re- [again]	The teacher has asked me to rewrite my essay.

Exercises

70.1 Write the opposite.

- 1

un

happy
- 2

able
- 3

correct
- 4

usual
- 5

possible
- 6

comfortable
- 7

agree
- 8

necessary
- 9

regular
- 10

honest
- 11

fair
- 12

lucky

70.2 Which sentence on the right logically follows each sentence on the left?

- 1

She arrived home.

b

a

She unpacked her suitcase.
- 2

Her essay was terrible.

b

She unlocked the front door.
- 3

She decided to go to bed.

c

She has disappeared.
- 4

He called her name.

d

She had overcharged me.
- 5

She's not here now.

e

She had to rewrite it.
- 6

He thought he was right.

f

She misheard it.
- 7

She got to the hotel.

g

She disagreed.
- 8

After I paid, I looked at the price.

h

She got undressed.

70.3 Complete the dialogues so that B agrees with A using different words. You only need one word for each gap.

- 1

A:

Adera is a strange name.

B:

Yes, very

unusual

.
- 2

A:

It's against the law, isn't it?

B:

Oh yes, it's

.
- 3

A:

You mean he took off all his clothes!

B:

Yes, he got completely

.
- 4

A:

He probably won't get back in time for the meeting.

B:

I agree. It's very

.
- 5

A:

A lot of the answers were wrong.

B:

Yes, I'm afraid they were nearly all

.
- 6

A:

He doesn't look in very good condition; he's a bit overweight.

B:

I know. He looks terribly

.
- 7

A:

Nobody thought this would happen.

B:

Yes, it was completely

.
- 8

A:

They never tell the truth.

B:

I know. They're both

.
- 9

A:

His business always seems to lose money, and it's not his fault.

B:

I know. He's very

.
- 10

A:

Ann always gives more attention to Sarah than she does to Lucas.

B:

Yes, it's very

on poor Lucas.

70.4 These words all appear in other units of the book. Do you know how to form the opposites?

- pleasant

unpleasant

fashionable
- kind

reliable
- patient (adj)

friendly
- suitable

tidy
- like (v)

ability
- do up

sociable